



THE BRANSON POLITICAL REVIEW

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ELECTION EDITION

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The Gray Area - in between the issues
that divide us

A NOTE FROM THE EDITOR

Hello, and welcome to the second edition of the Branson Political Review. It is with great pride that I bring you the work of these incredibly dedicated and talented student writers and researchers.

With the upcoming election I sought to give students an opportunity to be able to develop their belief systems as a collection of individual opinions rather than allegiance to a specific party or candidate. Often in Presidential elections the issues that matter get hidden behind the candidates themselves, making nuanced and complex issues polarizing. Thus, The Grey-Area was born in order combat this through the exploration of individual hot-button issues with research at its core.

A special thank you to Dr. Talia Di Manno for serving as our faculty advisor, assistant leader Alexander Moon for serving as co-editor, and Christopher Mao for developing the website.

Reese Furhman

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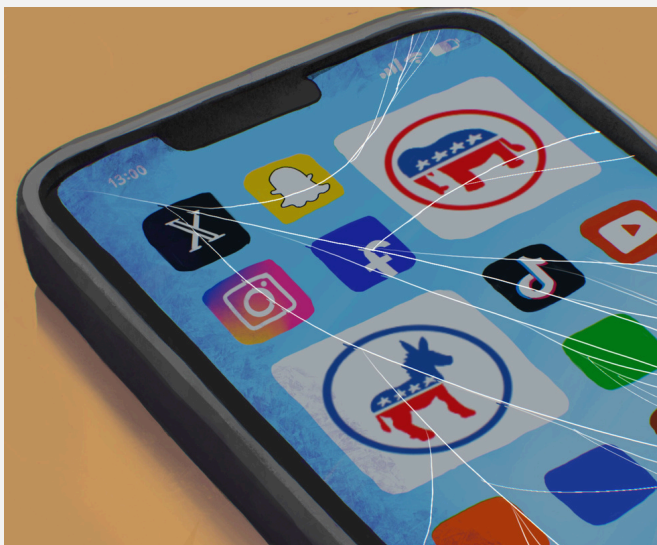
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THE SOCIAL MEDIA DIVIDE

By Sadie Winter

As we approach the 2024 presidential election, the country is as politically polarized as it's ever been. This is, in some part, due to the drastic differences in the ideologies of the candidates, but there are other factors at play in creating an environment of fierce opposition and debate. Social media platforms have contributed greatly to polarization through their algorithms designed to boost user engagement and increase companies' revenues.

A collection of political polls by the Pew Research Institute highlights how polarization has grown since the beginning of the 21st century. These first 2 polls show data up to 2014, and they highlight that political polarization had become more extreme even before Donald Trump won the 2016 presidential election. The polls show a shift away from moderate thinking and towards views based strictly on partisan lines.



Graphic by Sam Lehman

However, the divide goes beyond simple ideological differences and has taken on a more personal toll. Polls from both 2014 and, more recently, 2022 show that Americans believe people from the opposite party inherently possess undesirable qualities and even go so far as to say that they are a "threat to the nation's well-being". This ideological polarization has created a charged environment of antipathy towards Americans of the opposing party.

What does social media have to do with this increased polarization? The answer lies in the comes from the algorithms social media platforms use to suggest content for users. These algorithms collect data about the types of content users engage with and the people they follow in order to best predict users preferences. This becomes very problematic as when taken with the fact that social media has become a place where many Americans get their news. The algorithms use past data to suggest content that users will like, which means once an algorithm picks up on a user's ideological preferences, it will feed them content that aligns with those preferences. In 2017 a study published in PNAS took data from 376 million FaceBook users and 920 news outlets and found that "the more active a user is, the more the user tends to focus on a small number of news sources".

The study also found a "distinct community structure and strong user polarization" due to increased time spent on social media ([Schmidt](#)). This is problematic because it severely narrows a person's perception of the world when they are only exposed to one type of viewpoint. People's opinions are constantly reinforced because the algorithms feed them content that aligns with those opinions, so they are stuck in an echo chamber of their own beliefs.



Word Press

However, this alone doesn't fully account for the extreme polarization. The second piece to the puzzle is the extremity of viewpoints that the algorithm makes widely available. Social media algorithms are designed to engage viewers as much as possible in order to make the most money, and the statements and ideas that generate the most views and comments are the most provocative ones. As a result, social media has the effect of making extreme views seem much more widespread than they actually are. In fact, 70% of content about politics is generated by only 6% of the population, and those 6% are disproportionately very liberal or very conservative ([Woodruff](#)).

This illusion of widespread extremism creates a highly polarized environment where Americans see each other as on completely opposite sides, instead of attempting to find middle ground.

Finally, the anonymity of social media and the internet creates a breeding ground for ugly online fights in comment sections. Social media takes away the face-to-face interaction, which eliminates accountability and shared humanity. As comments get nastier, people become more entrenched against the opposing side, as this justifies their negative opinion.

Unfortunately, the result of this polarization is that most people see each other as political opinions and not human beings. And while the political issues that drive debates are important to resolve, the problem with social media is that it allows us to ignore the innate humanity of the person we are so fiercely against. How can we resolve our differences and begin to heal our nation in such a charged and unfriendly atmosphere? The first step to constructive discourse is placing curiosity before judgment. On social media, this means first, recognizing the harm algorithms have on dividing us, and second, trying to keep an open mind and explore ideas we normally aren't exposed to. Even if, after learning about the issues, we still believe in our original ideas, the process of learning rather than attacking or rebutting will allow us to understand each other better and have more compassion for one another. Once the conversation becomes less of an "us vs. them", we can start to work together to solve our problems. *ℬ*

WHERE THE CANDIDATES STAND: ABORTION

By Hazel Levinson

As the 2024 American presidential election approaches, one of the most contentious topics is abortion.

Many voters across the United States view abortion as a critical factor in selecting a political representative. As of June 2024, approximately 32% of voters say they will only support candidates who share their views on abortion, according to a [Gallup poll](#). This statistic underscores the importance of understanding candidates' positions on this issue.



AP News

This means an estimated one-third of Americans identify as single-issue voters, meaning their support hinges on a specific policy. Therefore, it's essential to clarify the facts to understand who you are endorsing and why.

In 2011, Donald Trump said "I'm pro-life, but I changed my view a number of years ago." During his 2016 presidential campaign, he criticized Planned Parenthood, saying "Millions of millions of women — cervical cancer, breast cancer — are helped by Planned Parenthood. I would defund it because I'm pro-life, but millions of women are helped by Planned Parenthood."

During his presidency, Trump appointed three judges to the Supreme Court who later voted in favor to overturn Roe V. Wade. In 2017, the White House proposed a 20-week national abortion ban and he encouraged the Senate to pass the act in 2018, though it ultimately did not succeed.

Now, in his current campaign, Trump claims he will serve as a "protector" of the American people, asserting that women "will be happy, healthy, confident and free. You will no longer be thinking about abortion."

But what does this really mean? It appears that Trump believes states should control abortion laws, recently stating, "All states will be different. Some will be more conservative than others. At the end of the day, this is all about the people."

While some may associate Trump with a supportive or resistant stance on abortion, his views seem to align with what he believes voters want to hear. Many find his shifting opinions concerning, as they may not know whether their views will be represented in office.

From describing himself as “very pro-choice” in 1999 to claiming he is “the most pro-life president” in 2023, citizens are left wondering whether his views evolve with experience or are merely political posturing.

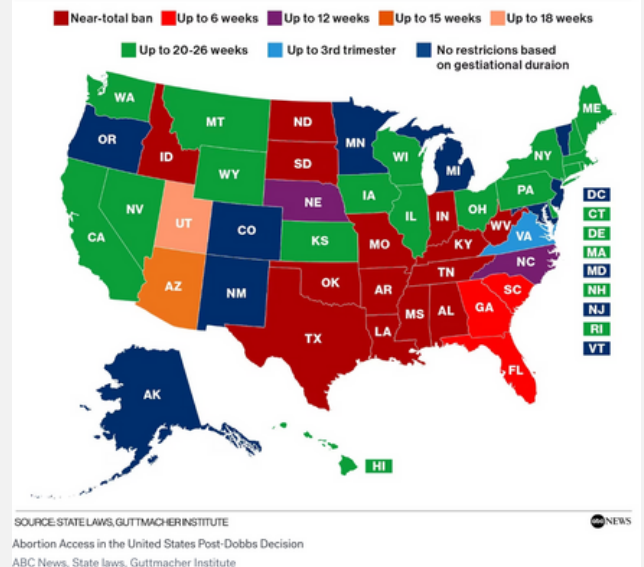
In contrast, Kamala Harris issued a statement on the Reproductive FACT Act, signed into law in 2015, expressing pride in her support for the Act because it “ensures that all women have equal access to comprehensive reproductive health care services, and that they have the facts they need to make informed decisions about their health and their lives.”

Throughout her political career, Harris has faced accusations from pro-life individuals and organizations of being too progressive on abortion. Following the passage of the Reproductive FACT Act, several anti-abortion groups sued to block the law, which was eventually overturned by the Supreme Court in 2018. This consistent criticism from similar groups suggests she has maintained a steady (if controversial) set of policies over time.

Recently, on the campaign trail, Harris has repeatedly declared her commitment to protecting abortion rights for every American. At a rally in Georgia, she remarked, “Trump still refuses to take accountability for the pain and suffering he has caused,” referencing a 2022 incident where a Georgian woman died due to pregnancy complications that could have been prevented if abortion had been accessible.

Abortion Access in the United States Post-Dobbs Decision

AS OF JUNE 21, 2024



During the 2024 Presidential debate, while Harris did not specify the laws she would enact around abortion, she emphasized her aim to “reinstate the protections of Roe,” which would prohibit states from denying access to abortions before approximately 20 weeks.

As the election draws near, it is crucial to clarify your facts regarding who you plan to vote for and why. Understanding the candidates' stances on abortion can help you make an informed choice that aligns with your values. Engaging with their policies and past actions will empower you to advocate for the issues that matter most to you and your community. In a time when reproductive rights are under intense scrutiny, being an informed voter is more important than ever. *B*

PROJECT 2025: A CRITICAL ANALYSIS

By Riley Sherman

Project 2025. A topic heard countless times throughout this year's election. It's discussed in debates, advertisements, the news, social media, in our own homes around the table. But how many voters know its contents? How much of an impact does this plan really have? This article will explore the policies and ideas behind Project 2025, specifically those about limiting the federal bureaucracy, as well as the ramifications of those policies.



Maine AFL CIO

The 2025 Presidential Transition Project is a roadmap for a far right presidency. It consists of four main parts: A policy agenda, a list of hand-picked political appointees to serve in the next administration, a training program intended to prepare the appointees within that list, and an exact playbook of policies for the first 180 days in office.

Most talked about in the media is the policy book, an over 900 page document titled *Mandate for Leadership: The Conservative Promise*. ([Mandate For Leadership PDF](#)) This is the ninth book of a series started in 1981, designed to recommend policies to the next Republican president in order to restrain the federal government and move it in a more conservative direction.

The *Mandate for Leadership* series and Project 2025 were both organized by The Heritage Foundation, a conservative think tank based in Washington D.C. It is the product of a collaboration between over 100 right-wing organizations. Contrary to popular belief, Donald Trump does not endorse Project 2025, and has made an effort to distance himself from the project, even calling parts of the plan "ridiculous and abysmal" ([Trump Post on Truth Social](#)). Despite that, several of Trump's policies throughout his presidency mirrored those stated in *The Conservative Promise*, and countless former Trump Administration officials are involved.

Project 2025 promises to "De-Weaponize the Federal Government", but what does that entail? The *Conservative Promise* lists numerous steps to limit the power of executive agencies, including: The Department of Agriculture, The Department of Education, The Department of Energy, The Department of Health and Human Services, and The Department of Labor. The following is a brief overview of the suggested policies on each.

The Department of Agriculture. According to The Conservative Promise, the sole purpose of the Department of Agriculture should be to "safely and efficiently produce food." It suggests legislation to promote the principle of prioritizing farmers over climate protection. It also calls for the reform or repeal of countless programs within the Department of Agriculture.

The Department of Education. It is Project 2025's intention to significantly limit the power of the Department of Education, and, eventually, eliminate it altogether. It presents testing data of fourth and eighth grade reading and math levels, claiming their decline in recent years is due to the reportedly convoluted nature of federal education programs (while ignoring the potential impact of the COVID-19 pandemic). The proposed solution to this is to undergo a thorough rearrangement of the department, removing agencies and regulations, and moving other functions to different departments. Additionally, it recommends a complete removal of Gender Ideology and Critical Race Theory from the classroom.

The Department of Energy. Similar to the Department of Agriculture, The Conservative Promise emphasizes the importance of affordable and abundant energy over addressing climate change. It declares that any attempt to combat climate change creates a fabricated energy shortage and causes the U.S. to rely on China and other countries for power. Furthermore, it states that federal control over energy leads to outsized control over the economy and the day-to-day lives of the American people.

The Department of Health and Human Services. Project 2025 seeks to further the conservative vision that a well-functioning family is one comprising a mother, working father, and children. Other proposals seek to limit the power of federal agencies such as the CDC and the FDA. It states the Biden administration promotes non-nuclear families and that the federal government should encourage traditional family dynamics. According to The Mandate for Leadership, the CDC should be split into two separate bodies, one that manages data-gathering and one that manages public health recommendations and policies.

The Department of Labor. The goal for the Department of Labor stated in The Conservative Promise is to abolish DEI and CRT programs from the American workplace. It believes workers should not be policed for all of their actions throughout the day and calls for the discontinuation of all consideration of race, gender, sexuality, and other minority designations within the workplace.

The common theme across all of these proposals is the goal of reducing the power of federal agencies. In terms of the Department of Labor, that would mean less protections for workers against discrimination. For the Department of Agriculture, it would mean less regulation over food production, potentially at the cost of food safety or achieving carbon emission goals. At their heart, the proposals work to limit the power of federal agencies and their ability to regulate industry.

As with any political document, Project 2025 has its inherent biases. When reading *The Conservative Promise*, there are many cases of misleading language or cherry picked quotations, in addition to underlying conservative assumptions being stated as fact. Project 2025 expounds with far right views, as showcased in its policies and beliefs about the dangers of the federal bureaucracy or the “deep state.” That being said, countless progressive news websites also do the same: cherry picking quotations and creating vast oversimplifications. As disagreeable as one might find the strong ideas within Project 2025, it is important to listen to what all sides have to say, and consider where there may be agreement. The Mandate for Leadership is simply a conservative starting point, and in all likelihood, any policies that get enacted will be moderated and reformed through the legislative process.

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NPR

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AMERICA'S PLACE IN THE WAR FOR UKRAINE

By Alex Moon



Quincy Institute

On February 24, 2024, Russia announced a "Special Military Operation" across their eastern border with Ukraine, citing "demilitarization and denazification" as their only goals. While Putin stated having ["no plans for an occupation of Ukrainian territories"](#), this "operation" quickly bloomed into the devastating conflict we now call the Russian invasion of Ukraine. Today, [Ukraine has recaptured 54% of once-lost territory, with Russia still occupying 18% of the country.](#) For Russia, capturing Ukraine would provide an invaluable buffer-zone to NATO-member countries such as Poland and Slovakia. Additionally, a decisive victory immediately following their invasion of Ukraine might have acted as a kind of "show of strength" on Russia's part; this has failed to materialize, and the currently drawn-out war has had a rather opposite effect.

To Ukraine's credit, fighting on their part can be described as nothing less than heroic. However, bravery alone does not win wars. The U.S has sent aid valued at \$106 billion; critics believe aid to Ukraine would be better spent on supporting American infrastructure, covering social security payments, or alleviating the myriad of other concerns plaguing the American government as of now.

However, this argument misunderstands the nature of the aid being sent to Ukraine. Of the \$106 billion dollars, only \$33.3 billion of it is classified as "budget support", or financial aid to assist Ukraine in its expenditures. The vast majority of aid falls under the classification of "Weapons, equipment, and other military support". Under this classification falls nearly every defense capability in existence: main battle tanks, drones, body armor, coastal defense systems, you name it. These portions of the U.S arsenal and their equivalent valuations are what comprise the brunt of the aid sent, not actual cash.

Furthermore, much of the weaponry sent to the firing-line in Europe would be considered "out-dated" by modern American standards. While potent when compared to similarly aging Russian technology, the technology being given to Ukrainians overwhelmingly comes from U.S warehouses and stores, rather than the production line. . It's not as if the U.S is hindering its own military capacity through these aid packages; in fact, we are learning valuable lessons from these vehicle's deployments against one of our primary adversaries.

For example, the proliferation of FPV (first person view) drones loaded with explosives as an anti-armor measure may have encouraged American research into anti drone technologies: just this April, the U.S deployed actual laser-cannons overseas in an undisclosed location. By giving Ukraine our technological "hand-me-downs", we can see how they would perform against a near-peer adversary and inform our future research & development decisions accordingly.

So, how does this play into the election? Unsurprisingly, the two candidates' views on the war in Ukraine differ substantially. When asked if he would support a NATO-affiliated country that spent less than 2% of its GDP on military defense, Donald Trump stated, "No, I would not protect you...in fact, I would encourage them (Russia) to do whatever the hell they want". This statement, while seemingly outrageous, does reflect a facet of American sentiment gaining in popularity - that America is saddled with defending the West while European countries spend their excess funds on healthcare and other amenities. Trump advances an "America First" doctrine that approaches alliances as "temporary alignments of interest", rather than relationships to be cultivated. Critics of this strategy are quick to mention its rather heartless nature; the America we live in today was built on cooperative globalism and collective purpose/action, not clawing our way to the top of some zero-sum mountain.

Kamala Harris presents a much more traditional approach to foreign policy. She would have the U.S remain a committed member of NATO, much as it is today, and has said that the U.S should "remain committed to ensuring a victory against Russia's "unprovoked aggression" in Ukraine". Her stance models after current president Joe Biden's foreign policy, and falls closely in line with contemporary Democratic leanings.

With either candidate assuming the office, a victory in Ukraine should be of utmost importance. Russia's deliberate invasion of Ukraine is in direct violation of the Charter of the United Nations, and encourages a near-future dominated by large-scale, nation-to-nation warfare. The U.S would be remiss to entangle themselves in another conflict; wars tend to be non-productive for the prosperity of a country. A victory in Ukraine without direct American engagement would prove invaluable, both for the good of our nation and the global network we've worked so hard to achieve. 

THE FORGOTTEN IMPACT OF LOCAL CANDIDATES

By Reese Fuhman

Today, National candidates dominate political conversation. In most cases, voters are more interested in what a presidential candidate says in a rally across the country than the basic policies of local candidates and propositions.

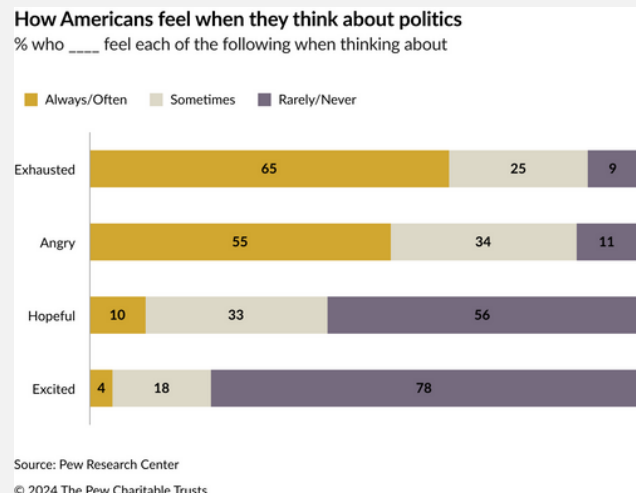
We embellish our yards with signs for presidential candidates and make bring rhetoric of National elections to our cities and neighborhoods. However, as a society it seems we have forgotten that local decisions often impact our daily lives the most. Local politicians - be it mayors, city council people, school board members, etc - decide the fate that road that won't get repaired, not National politicians.

The impact of politicians on our everyday lives operates in an inverted triangle - those most proximate to us have the most potential to cause change in our immediate lives. Yet these positions are most often forgotten and overlooked.

But why is this the case?

Generally, there is an attribution of local politics with being boring or pointless. Is it possible that we are smitten with being one level removed from the political conversation. We can talk about National candidates in a way we wouldn't be able to if we knew them personally. By the end of a campaign cycle presidential candidates become more ideal than human. An amalgamation of everything they have ever done and plan to do, the insults they receive and the party they are meant to embody. Dissimilarly, local politicians are often our neighbors, our acquaintances and proximate friends. We see them in the grocery store, on a morning walk or on a morning commute. Particularly in the "small world" web of proximate social connections of the Bay Area and Marin County in particular.

Local politicians reveal to us that the people making policy decisions are human - undermining idealization of elected officials, and a false illusion of being helpless in the things that happen politically.



The upcoming election is one riddled with catastrophization. According to a study done by Pew this year 55% of Americans feel angry always or often when thinking about politics, and only 4% feel excited ([Pew](#)). Angry apathy is a potent contagion infecting our society and jeopardizing American Democracy. So many Americans express angst at feeling like there is "nothing they can do." But there is. The president is far from the end all be all of our political system, instead the success of our democracy is contingent on the work of each public servant no matter how big or small and the electorate to inform themselves and vote honorably. Be it for the President of the United States or the Town Water Board each vote matters in how our future will look. *B*

THE STATE OF IMMIGRATION

By Grant Kruttschnitt

"Immigration is not just a link to America's past; it's also a bridge to America's future." - George H.W. Bush ([UCSB](#))



Workpermit.com

In the last few years, there has been a shift in public sentiment about immigration towards anti-immigration, both in the U.S. and internationally ([Politico](#)). This has caused far-right factions such as the UK Reform and increasingly extremist elements within the US Republican party to come to power.

However, in the United States, anti-immigration sentiment is somewhat present in both parties. This sentiment is much stronger in the Republican party than the Democratic Party. In the mainstream Democrats, there isn't much anti-immigration sentiment; moreover, a lacking appetite for expanding legal immigration. However, there is some negative talk from the more progressive side of the party.

Bernie Sanders, a Vermont Senator, and primary Presidential candidate in 2016 and 2020, "Open borders? That's a Koch Brothers idea" ([Youtube](#)). The Koch Brothers are brothers who have pushed for more pro-business and libertarian policies ([BBC](#)). He's basically saying that only corporations want to have a lot of immigration, because they will be able to exploit immigrants and not pay American workers as good of a wage as before. This rhetoric also appears from unions, although less so now ([Newsweek](#)).

Republicans are much worse, though. Entire campaigns are made up of doomsaying about the border crisis, from Trump's first speech in 2016 saying that some immigrants, "I assume are good people," to Trump now saying that Haitian immigrants living in Springfield are "eating the dogs ... eating the cats" ([ABC News](#)). Trump's best quadrant by issue is from those who say immigration is their biggest issue, getting double Clinton's share in that population ([NYTimes](#)).



AP News

However, I posit that immigration is a great thing for our country, and we should focus on getting more of it in better ways. I put forward a case for it, discuss potential issues of immigration, and talk about ways of improving immigration systems.

The Economic Case

The first immigration benefits are rooted in economics. Anti-immigration activists often mention that "immigrants are taking our jobs and lowering our wages". This is simply untrue. At first glance, it might make sense because immigration mean more supply of workers, which would meet labor demands, and lower wages. However, this is the lump of labour fallacy: thinking that there is only a fixed amount of labour in the United States that is needed. It forgets about the second part of Econ 101, demand. While immigrants lead to a greater supply of workers, they also lead to a greater demand of workers. They purchase items, resulting in more jobs being created. In addition, immigrants also create more small businesses than the average American, which leads to more jobs being created than are taken up, according to many studies regarding the subject ([NBER](#)).



SBA Advocacy

However, theoretically, the jobs they create could be worse than the ones that they take up. Economies could also be worse when there are more immigrants compared to when there are none. That is not the case, though. Even asylum seekers in Europe, who aren't vetted for their job credentials the same way that legal immigrants in America have to be, have been proven to assist their countries' economic performance ([Science.org](#)).

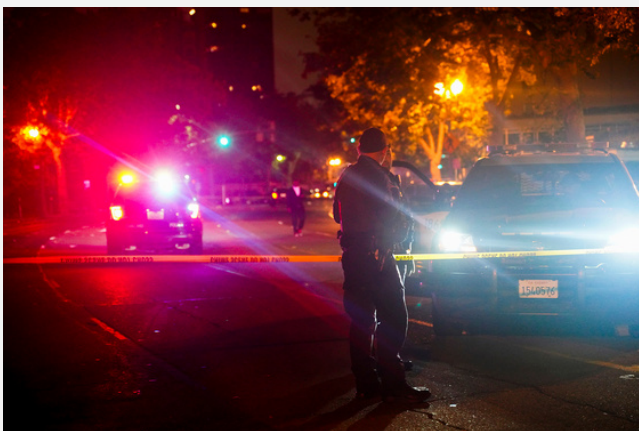
That isn't even the only economic benefit. Another big benefit is that immigrants make goods cheaper ([UChicago](#)). This part is because immigrants are often willing to work for a lower wage than Americans would. This means that goods can be produced for lower prices, and savings are passed on to the consumer.

Immigrants help increase the GDP of their countries because there's an extra worker, but what's less obvious is that they also increase GDP per capita, which means native-born Americans get their income increased ([ELibrary](#)). In addition, even if they just helped increase GDP while keeping GDP per capita the same, that would be good for us. More GDP gives America more influence on the world stage due to us being able to spend more on issues, and other countries want access to big economies. This allows us to do everything from climate change treaties to helping defend democracy by funding Ukraine more effectively.

But let's say that's convinced you. Maybe immigrants really do both create better jobs, make goods cheaper, and increase salaries of Native-Born Americans. But what about immigrants taking welfare from the government, which drains it from helping Native-Born Americans? Well, that has also not been proven. Of the various studies that have been done on the topic, almost all of them show that immigrants have values of zero fiscal impact on the government ([CATO](#)). And that is great considering that immigrants have a positive economic impact.

The False Dangers of Immigration

The secondary fear is how immigrants are dangerous and have repressive ideas. There is a lot of fear surrounding the immigrants themselves, ranging from outlandish claims such as Donald Trump saying we have "people that are from mental institutions, insane asylum, terrorists" ([CNN](#)), to somewhat more reasonable claims such as thinking that they will commit crimes at a greater rate than native-born Americans. However, immigrants commit less crime than U.S.-born citizens ([Brennan Center](#)).



Brennan Center

The third fear, mostly held by liberals or those who want to appeal to liberal voters, is regarding repressive ideas. Many worry that immigrants, especially Muslim immigrants, having more right-wing views on many social issues could lead to backtracking for women's and LGBTQ+ rights, especially in Europe. The AFD, Germany's far right party, runs ads saying that Muslims are "a big danger to our state, our society, and our system of values" ([Georgetown](#)). A majority of the country agrees with them, as 60% of the population believes that Islam does not belong to Germany ([Reuters](#)). They worry that immigrants will degrade institutions, causing society to fail. In some cases, the worry about Muslim immigrants having different values is true. They do often support gay marriage and abortion less than the average person in European countries. However, immigrants often integrate quickly, and the attitudes of the second generation converge "with native-born attitudes on many important social issues" ([NAP](#)).

Another important fact about this is that the difference in opinion is not as big in the U.S. Compared to France, Germany, and the UK; the U.S. has the lowest difference of opinions on abortion and gay rights ([CATO](#)). It is also the only country where immigrants aren't less likely to have a job than Native Born Citizens. The fact that it varies between countries shows that it is not an immigrant problem, but an immigration system problem.

The three main factors that vary between the U.S., and Europe when it comes to immigration systems are social welfare being greater in Europe, job regulation being stricter in Europe, and the U.S. having a big culture of immigration, despite some people now trying to get away from that culture. The first two factors both discourage immigrants from finding jobs. The third makes it easier for immigrants to integrate. This suggests that it is the various different policies and the culture surrounding immigration that cause these negative effects of immigration, not the actual immigrants themselves.

In addition, immigrants trust American institutions greater than native-born Americans([SSRN](#)), which binds America closer together. A liberal democracy and rule of law only works when political institutions have authority and trust, and immigrants help advance this.

Now, let's talk about the immigrants themselves. Some people try to claim that these immigrants are exploited, so we should not take them in at all. Sadly, some illegal immigrants definitely are, when they have their documentation taken away and they get blackmailed by employers. However, immigrants being paid less than native workers is not exploitation inherently, even though some people argue it is. It's hard for many US-born Americans, who are so privileged just by virtue of the location of our birth, to realize how much immigrants are getting from this. It's still much more difficult for immigrants to succeed than the average native-born American.

However, it's still better for them than the often ten times worse pay at home, to say nothing of the horrible political conditions they are facing, such as Mexico's cartels, or the authoritarian republic of Venezuela. There's a reason that immigrants are willing to spend tens of thousands of dollars and risk their lives just on the journey to America.



CNN

Even when talking about immigrants from more upper-class countries, it's obviously that it's better for them here, either economically or socially, because they wouldn't have come otherwise. And when it helps us too, there's no reason to stop them.

The Steel Manned Opposing Case

While there is much uninformed, racist rationale used to slow immigration, it would be disingenuous to lump factual reasons in those.

One of the potential problems with too much immigration is housing. Due to a lot of housing problems (excessive regulation, zoning, lack of workers), the housing supply cannot effectively adapt to the new demand from immigrants

This drives prices up and exacerbates the housing crisis that we already have. This is a strong argument, as it already happens in places like Canada ([Financial Times](#)). Obviously, there can be a lot of housing supply reform and there should be, but it will not happen instantaneously. However, immigrants do make up a large part of the construction industry, as nearly 25 percent of construction workers are foreign-born, compared to 14 percent of the nation ([Research: New American Economy](#)). This does somewhat offset the increased demand, as these new workers drive housing prices down, and cause more housing to be produced, but immigrants overall lead to an increase in housing pricing.

Another problem is if immigrants overwhelmingly go into a specific field, like construction above, American workers in that field will have their wages lowered. That's because the labor supply in that field would outmatch the increased demand for it. There would still be net benefits for society, but there would be concentrated negative effects.

Lastly, public systems, like healthcare, and infrastructure generally, just like housing, often aren't able to have their supply increased rapidly. This can be improved with better policy, but obviously, it will remain to some extent.

These effects haven't happened in great effect in the US, because we mostly have numbers of immigrants below the percent that this would require. However, they do happen in some places, so it is important to be aware of them.



UConn Today

Ways of Making Immigration Better

Throughout this paper, I've made the case that immigration, as it currently exists, is largely a great thing. However, it does have its share of problems, both in Europe and in the United States. However, there are ways to expand those benefits of immigration while minimizing those problems.

In the United States, a big problem is the asylum system's efficacy versus the normal immigration pathways. For almost any immigrant, it's much easier to enter the country illegally to try to get asylum, knowing that your case won't go to court for years, instead of trying to get a green card. In some cases, even immigrants from China will fly to Mexico to enter the border.

This is ridiculous, because this system misaligns incentives for immigrants. Immigrants that have a lot to lose like having a great job might not take this route, even though we might actually want them more.

A way to expedite this is to do what the Biden administration and Congress planned to do: hire more border judges to try asylum cases quicker. However, Trump wanted to campaign on the Democrats not having done anything on the border, and he was able to put enough pressure on the Congressional republicans so they wouldn't pass it. Asylum cases would be tried much quicker, and the people that would be granted asylum wouldn't have to sit through years of uncertainty, and make it so those who don't have a valid claim of asylum wouldn't even come through that process, as they know they would be rejected quickly.

Another way for fixing the asylum process would be to do what Trump did: make agreements with other Latin American countries to have immigrants go there first when seeking asylum instead of heading here ([Reuters](#)). I think that the border bill is a slightly better approach, as the agreements with other Latin American countries make it harder for those who have legitimate asylum reasons, and are somewhat cruel.

Those changes should allow us to expand the legal immigration pathways. There are many ways that legal immigration pathways could be expanded positively. It should be much easier for someone to get a work visa, and to renew it. It's needlessly regulated with too many restrictions. For example, for Green Cards, employers often have to pay immigration attorneys if they want to give out green cards, due to the complexity of it ([NOLO](#)). It can also take up to several years before employees are approved ([NOLO](#)).



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It could be easier for foreign university students, or anyone who possesses valuable skills, who had come to the U.S. to get a green card after graduating, to get their expertise. It is ridiculous that we let so many talented people slip by because of false economic worry. To go along with this, many professions have needless regulations that prevent people from working in them. One of the most important professions, and one we're facing a shortage of, doctors, are forced to do residency again if they're moving to the US to work, even if they have many years of experience in nations comparable to ours ([PBS](#)). This is ridiculous, and while they may inflate the wages of those who are in those specific industries, it is worse for society overall.

We could also make another simple immigration pathway that would just require immigrants to pay a certain amount of money, let's say 100,000 dollars. Proponents like Gary Becker, a winner of the Nobel Memorial Prize in Economic Sciences, have also proposed this, saying that it will lead to higher-skilled workers coming, as they would be able to make the payment back easier, and only people who really want to come to the U.S. would come ([IEA](#)).

It's an elegant free market solution that would select for the people that America would most want. We could then use that money to fund the new border system or use it to stop some of the problems associated with immigration, by ways like funding new housing or getting public services expanded to deal with the increased population. The money could also theoretically be used as a dividend to all citizens, which would make this pathway more popular.

Obviously, that wouldn't work as the only immigration pathway, but it would be a great additional path to becoming an American.

Conclusion

Sadly, I doubt that many of these reforms will come soon. While there is a chance that the border security bill could pass if Harris is elected, the increase in legal immigration might not come along with it, which could just leave us worse off. On the other side, Trump's mass deportation is intensely damaging on so many levels, and it can only be hoped that he doesn't win and that his administration would lack the competency to actually accomplish it. Hopefully, by the next election, the political consensus will shift on immigration. *B*